

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN RUSSIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

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INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Why This Matters

Across Russia, communities discover that the forest they gather in, the river they drink from, the air over their town, or the hill above their village has been assigned to a project decided far away. A landfill for another region's waste. A mine or a smelter. A pulp mill. A quarry. A pipeline. A logging concession. A chemical or waste-incineration plant. The first sign is often a survey crew, a fence, a notice buried in an official bulletin, or a rumour that trainloads of Moscow's rubbish are bound for your district.

This guide is a practical manual for those people. It explains, in concrete steps, how the approval system for large projects is supposed to work in Russia, where the narrow genuine openings are, what documentation actually matters, how to organise as safely as possible, and how to use the specific levers that have, in rare but real cases, worked here. It does not promise victory. It promises a clear-eyed method that gives you the best possible chance while keeping you and your neighbours as safe as circumstances allow — and in Russia, safety is not a footnote. It is the first consideration on every page.

You must hear the hardest truth before anything else, because everything depends on it. Russia is one of the most dangerous places in the world in which to oppose a project the state wants. Courts are not independent. Independent and federal environmental advocacy has been effectively dismantled: the largest organisations have been branded "undesirable" or "foreign agents" and forced to close or flee, and any cooperation with a banned organisation, or being labelled a "foreign agent" yourself, carries severe legal consequences. Public protest is tightly restricted, and since 2022 activists have been prosecuted under wartime laws for "discrediting the armed forces" or spreading "false information." Framing a fight as political, anti-authority, or anti-war is not only ineffective here — it is acutely dangerous, and can bring prison. This does not mean nothing can be done. It means the methods that work in Russia are extremely narrow, and using the wrong one can destroy lives for no gain. The whole of this guide is built around that reality.

And yet — this is the second truth, and it is real — communities in Russia have stopped destructive projects. Residents of the far north forced the cancellation of a vast Arctic landfill built to take Moscow's trash. Protesters in the southern Urals protected a sacred hill from soda-ash mining and had it turned into a protected natural area. Campaigners in the Far East saved a rare whale population. These wins were narrow, local, disciplined, and rigorously non-political — grievances about a specific harm to a specific place, never challenges to the system — and that is exactly why they were, in the end, tolerated and even resolved. They show that within Russia's system there is a slender, conditional space in which a determined local community can prevail. This guide is about finding and using that space, and about the danger that

surrounds it.

The projects that damage communities in Russia follow resources and the disposal of other regions' burdens: mining, oil and gas, timber, metals, and the landfills and incinerators that carry the waste of the big cities into the provinces. What they share is that the people who profit rarely live where the harm lands, and the people who bear the harm are rarely asked in time to matter.

The Strategic Framework

The core of this guide is a simple idea: **a destructive project is not a single event but a chain of decisions, and a chain can be broken at its weakest link.** Your job is to find that link and place your limited, careful strength there — never confronting the whole project, and never the system, head-on.

Every large project in Russia depends on a sequence: it must fit official plans; for listed activities it must pass a State Environmental Expertise and, before that, an environmental impact assessment (OVOS) that by law includes public participation; it must secure land, permits, and financing; and then it is built. Each stage has documents that must exist and procedures that must be followed. Every requirement is a potential point of failure for the project — and a potential, if narrow, point of leverage for you.

In Russia the strongest link is the political will of the authorities backing the project, which you cannot move directly and must never attack openly. But the chain has weaker links. A project that skipped its required environmental expertise or its public consultation is procedurally vulnerable — and, in principle, a decision reached without the legally required public participation can be challenged and the works halted. A project that harms a specially protected natural area, or that a large and purely local community opposes on concrete environmental grounds, can become a problem the authorities prefer to defuse rather than defend. And Russia's peculiar geography of grievance — the big cities exporting their waste and their costs to the regions — sometimes turns a local fight into one the federal centre itself chooses to resolve. Your task is to find which of these narrow links applies to your project.

Critical Caveat: A Tilted System Can Make Opposition Harder (But Doesn't Make It Impossible)

Throughout this guide you will find honest assessments, because a guide that promised you could stop any project by filing the right objection would be lying, and in Russia that lie could put people in prison. Here is the honest frame.

When a project inflicts a concrete, visible harm on a large local community — a landfill, a poisoned river, a threatened protected area — and can be opposed on strictly local, apolitical environmental grounds, it is genuinely, if narrowly, vulnerable. Russia's real community victories all have this shape: a specific, tangible threat; a broad and disciplined local public; a rigorously non-political frame; and authorities who, faced with sustained local anger they could not simply ignore, chose to resolve the grievance.

When a project is remote, strategically or economically important to the state, and affects a small or dispersed community, stopping it outright is extremely unlikely, and confrontation is dangerous. For these, realistic goals are narrower: use the formal procedures to force honest assessment and consultation, document violations, pursue enforcement of the state's own environmental standards, and win mitigation or compensation — all pursued with extreme care.

Knowing which situation you are in — before you act — is the single most important judgment you will make, because in Russia the wrong method does not merely waste effort; it can bring criminal prosecution. Much of this guide is designed to help you judge accurately and act only in the narrow, careful ways the system sometimes permits.

How to use this guide

Read the whole thing once before you do anything, and read the section "When the System Is Tilted" early, because in Russia it governs how every other step must be done. Two principles run through every page. First, **safety and apolitical framing before everything**: keep any fight strictly local, strictly about a concrete environmental harm, and never political, anti-authority, or anti-war — and understand that even then, risk remains and must be weighed. Second, **use the state's own rules where you can**: the environmental-expertise and OVOS procedures, the protected-areas law, and the complaint and prosecutorial channels are the terrain on which a careful community occasionally holds ground — the state's own instruments, turned to protect a specific place.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot break a chain you cannot see. This section maps the bodies that decide, the journey a project takes, the rules that govern it, the incentives that bias it, and the overseers who matter — so you can find where your project is narrowly vulnerable, and do so without exposing yourself.

The Bodies That Decide — And What Each One Controls

The Ministry of Natural Resources and Environment, and Rosprirodnadzor. The federal ministry sets environmental policy and, through the State Environmental Expertise, reviews whether listed projects comply with environmental requirements. Rosprirodnadzor — the Federal Service for Supervision of Natural Resources — is the environmental inspectorate: it supervises compliance, investigates violations, and can act against a project breaching the rules. These are the bodies whose procedures a project must satisfy, and therefore whose decisions are worth scrutinising for procedural failure.

Regional and local authorities. Russia is a federation, and much depends on the level at which a project is decided. Regional governments and their environmental bodies, and municipal administrations, handle land allocation, local permits, and many approvals, and they run the public hearings attached to planning and assessment. They are frequently the project's local sponsors, courting the investment — but they are also closest to the affected public, and the level at which local pressure is most directly felt.

The State Environmental Expertise (gosekspertiza). For activities on the statutory list, a project must pass the State Environmental Expertise — an official review of whether the planned activity complies with environmental requirements, issued as a binding conclusion. A positive conclusion is a legal precondition for many projects; a project that proceeded without a required expertise, or whose expertise rested on a defective assessment or absent public consultation, is procedurally exposed.

The land, forest, water, and subsoil authorities. Allocation of land, forest plots, water use, and mineral or subsoil rights runs through the relevant codes and agencies. Who controls the paperwork over the specific ground, trees, water, or minerals a project needs is frequently the decisive, and most challengeable, question.

The prosecutor's office (prokuratura). The prosecutor's office exercises broad "general supervision" over the legality of official acts and can be petitioned to check whether a project or an official decision complied with the law. It is not independent of the state, and it will not act against a project the state prioritises — but on a clear, documented, apolitical violation of environmental law it is a recognised channel that sometimes produces a response.

The courts. Courts are not independent and will not rule against a strategically-backed project on political grounds. But administrative challenges to specific unlawful decisions are formally available, and the law provides that a project's environmental decision reached without required public consultation can be challenged and, in principle, its validity terminated — a narrow but real procedural hook.

How a Decision Is Actually Made — The Journey of a Project

Knowing the sequence tells you when to act, because each stage has a window and a document.

Stage 1 — Planning and siting. The project is written into territorial and land-use plans, and land or resource rights are allocated. Planning documents are subject to public hearings. This early stage sets the terms; a project that does not fit an approved plan, or whose plan skipped its required hearing, is exposed.

Stage 2 — OVOS (environmental impact assessment). For listed projects, the developer must prepare an environmental impact assessment and an environmental impact statement, and the authorities must organise consultation and public participation, including public hearings on the assessment materials. This is the stage where the public has a defined, on-the-record role — and the stage most often done badly: hearings announced obscurely, held far away or at inconvenient times, materials made effectively inaccessible, objections ignored, or attendance stage-managed. Every such defect is a documented procedural violation.

Stage 3 — State Environmental Expertise. The completed assessment and project materials go to the State Environmental Expertise, which issues its binding conclusion. The conclusion and the process behind it — including whether public consultation genuinely occurred — are the pivot on which a procedural challenge turns.

Stage 4 — Permits, land, and construction. With a positive expertise, the developer secures construction and sector permits, finalises land or resource rights, arranges financing, and begins. Each permit is a separate decision with its own legality; and where land, forest, or a protected area is involved, that is often where the clearest and most personal illegality lies.

Stage 5 — Operation. Once running, a facility must meet discharge and emission standards and permit conditions and is

subject to Rosprirodnadzor supervision. A facility exceeding its limits is exposed to enforcement — a reminder that the fight does not necessarily end at construction.

The Rulebook — The Provisions That Decide the Outcome

You do not need to be a lawyer, but you must know the handful of instruments that govern your fight:

- **The Federal Law "On Environmental Protection" (No. 7-FZ, 2002)** — the framework law, establishing the OVOS and expertise system, environmental standards, and the public's environmental rights.
- **The Federal Law "On Ecological Expertise" (No. 174-FZ, 1995)** — governs the State Environmental Expertise and, importantly, the **Public Ecological Expertise**, a mechanism by which a qualifying public organisation may conduct its own environmental review of a project, whose approved conclusion carries legal weight.
- **The OVOS Regulations** — the detailed procedure for the impact assessment and its public participation, aligned in part with the Espoo Convention on transboundary impact assessment, to which Russia is a party.
- **The Federal Law "On Specially Protected Natural Areas" (No. 33-FZ, 1995)** — the protection regime for reserves, national parks, and natural monuments; securing or invoking protected status has, in practice, saved threatened sites.
- **The Land, Forest, Water, and Subsoil Codes** — governing the allocation and use of the specific resources a project needs, and the source of many concrete, documentable breaches.

The pattern to hold in mind: the OVOS and expertise rules give you procedure, a defined public voice, and a narrow challenge if consultation was skipped; the Public Ecological Expertise gives an organised community a formal counter-review; the protected-areas law can lock a place away from development; and the resource codes are where specific, personal illegality often lies.

Follow the Money — Why the System Often Leans Toward "Yes"

Understand the incentives and you understand why the gate is so often open. Resource extraction and the disposal of the big cities' waste generate revenue and serve powerful state and corporate interests, and officials are rewarded for delivering investment, not for protecting a provincial forest or river. The people who bear the harm are far from the people who profit. Sector authorities are proponents, not referees. This is not a system with a neutral referee awaiting persuasion on the merits; on a project the state wants, the default is approval. Your leverage therefore rarely comes from convincing the decision-maker that the project is bad. It comes from raising the cost — procedural, and above all the political cost of a large, visible, purely local grievance the authorities would rather resolve than let fester.

The Overseers — Who Watches the Decision-Makers

In Russia the overseers are not independent courts, a free press, or an opposition. Most channels that other countries rely on — independent NGOs, international organisations, foreign lenders — have been severed here by the "undesirable" and "foreign agent" laws and by sanctions. What remains is narrow and works only within the system:

- **Rosprirodnadzor and the environmental inspection**, which can act on a documented, apolitical violation of environmental standards.
- **The prosecutor's office**, which can be petitioned to check the legality of an official decision or a project, and sometimes responds to a clear environmental-law breach.
- **The State Environmental Expertise process itself**, whose procedural requirements — especially genuine public consultation — give a narrow ground of challenge.
- **The federal centre's own preference, at times, to defuse a large local grievance** rather than let regional anger grow — the dynamic behind more than one Russian community victory.
- **A shrinking but not extinct independent and exile media and surviving local networks**, which can carry a documented, strictly-local, apolitical environmental story to a wider public — a channel that must be used with great care given the wartime information laws.

These are the only overseers your strategy can realistically reach. Much of the rest of this guide is about producing documentation strong enough to move them, and doing so in the narrow, careful, apolitical way that keeps your people out of prison.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit, calibrate honestly — and weigh the danger, which in Russia is severe. These figures are **directional**,

not guarantees — patterns from how Russian community responses tend to go, especially since 2022, not a controlled study. The decisive variable is not in the table: **whether the project is a concentrated, imported harm a large local public rejects on strictly apolitical grounds, or a remote, strategically important one.** For the first, a narrow space exists; for the second, discount every figure and read Section 13 first. Keep every approach strictly local, technical, and non-political.

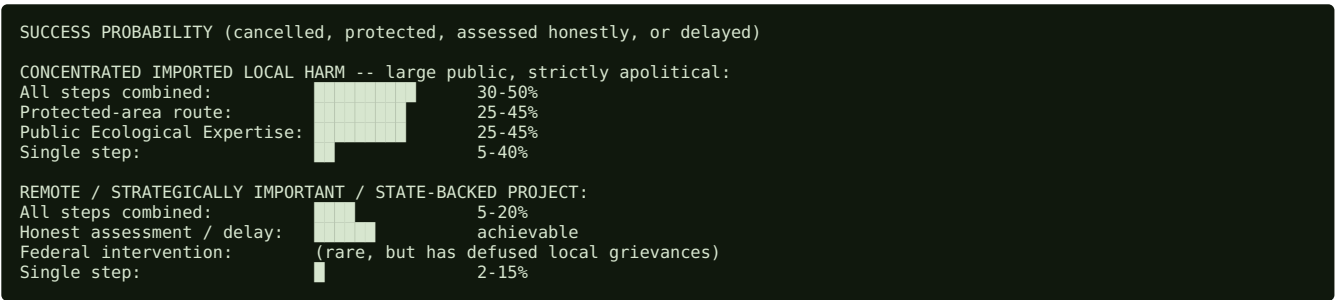
Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	1-3 months	low	Basis for every other step
Comments at the OVOS public hearing	20-40%	during review	low	On record; conditions or a redo
Public Ecological Expertise (qualifying org)	25-45%	3-18 months	low-moderate	Formal counter-review contesting the basis
OVOS / no-consultation legal challenge	20-40%	6-24 months	moderate	Decision challenged; works halted; delay
Rosprirodnadzor enforcement complaint	20-40%	1-9 months	low	Inspection; fine; order; record
Prosecutor (prokuratura) application	20-40%	1-9 months	low	Legality checked; measures ordered
Protected-area status secured/invoked	25-45%	6-36 months	low-moderate	Site placed beyond development
All steps combined (imported local harm)	30-50%	12-48 months	low-moderate	Cancelled, protected, assessed, or delayed
All steps combined (remote / strategic project)	5-20%	12-48 months	low-moderate	Honest assessment, mitigation, delay

Key insight: all steps together beat any single one, and Russia's real strengths are the **OVOS public-consultation requirement** (a decision reached without it can be challenged and halted), the **Public Ecological Expertise**, the **protected-areas route**, the **prosecutor and inspectorate**, and above all the **federal centre's occasional preference to defuse a large local grievance**. Its constraints are severe: **non-independent courts**, **dismantled independent advocacy** (foreign-agent and undesirable bans), **near-extinct assembly rights**, **wartime repression**, and **largely severed external leverage**.

A note on cost: commenting, requesting and complaining are inexpensive and lower-risk. The expenditure that changes outcomes is a trustworthy lawyer and a qualifying organisation for the Public Ecological Expertise — chosen with great care for their legal exposure.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The arguments that move outcomes in Russia are **strictly technical, local, and apolitical** — **grounded in the environmental rules and a specific place, never in opposition to authority or the war.** The strongest: a **skipped or defective public consultation**, a **threat to a specially protected area**, an **unlawful resource allocation**, and a **large, disciplined, purely local grievance** that the federal centre may prefer to defuse. What will not work — and is acutely dangerous — is any political, national, or anti-war framing, or contact with a banned organisation.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The federal-versus-local dynamic** — a large local grievance the centre may choose to resolve.

2. **Procedure and the courts** — the OVOS/consultation challenge and the Public Ecological Expertise.
3. **The protected-areas route** — locking a qualifying site away from development.
4. **The prosecutor and inspectorate** — the state's own legality and enforcement channels.
5. **Documentation** — the secure, dated record every step and every protection depends on.

What Russian Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **The concrete local grievance is the tolerated space** — large, disciplined, apolitical resistance to a specific harm has, in high-profile cases, forced the state to retreat. **A northern region refusing a distant city's waste** (Shiyes) was abandoned after sustained local protest; **a sacred hill in the south** (Kushtau) was saved and made a protected area after mass mobilisation. **Formal procedure bites, narrowly** — a project that skipped consultation is exposed, and the Public Ecological Expertise and protected-area status are real tools. **Enforcement channels sometimes act** on a clear, apolitical breach. **And external leverage is largely gone** — sanctions and the bans have severed the international routes other communities rely on, so the levers are almost entirely domestic. The through-line, and the warning: **stay rigorously local and non-political, use the state's own procedures, and protect your people above all — the aftermath of even a victory has brought imprisonment.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Before you write a word or gather a neighbour, you must know exactly what you are fighting, who is behind it, where in its chain it is weakest — and, in Russia above all, how to frame the fight so it stays local, apolitical, and as safe as possible. Acting before you know these things wastes effort and can expose people to grave risk. Spend your first days answering five questions.

The Five Questions

1. **What exactly is the project, and where is it in the approval sequence?** Is it being sited and planned, is the OVOS or its public hearing under way, has the State Environmental Expertise been issued, or is land being taken and construction begun? The stage tells you which window is open now and which deadline is nearest. A project still in assessment or awaiting expertise is far more open to influence than one already approved.
2. **Who is behind it, and how important is it to the state?** Identify the developer and, crucially, how strategically or economically important the project is to regional or federal authorities. A landfill imported from another region, opposed by the receiving community, is a very different fight from a strategic extractive project central to state revenue. The strength and level of the official stake shape both your odds and, decisively, your risk.
3. **Is there a federal-versus-regional or city-versus-province dimension?** Does the project impose one region's or city's burden on another's people — waste, pollution, a facility no one nearby wants? This dynamic is distinctively powerful in Russia: a purely local grievance against an imported harm can, in the right circumstances, become one the federal centre itself chooses to resolve to quiet regional anger.
4. **Which decision and which violation are genuinely challengeable?** Is the weak point a skipped or defective public consultation, a missing or flawed environmental expertise, a threat to a specially protected area, or an unlawful allocation of land, forest, water, or subsoil? Usually one link is weaker and safer to press than the others. Find it.
5. **Can the fight be kept strictly local and apolitical — and what is the risk?** This question is not optional in Russia; it is the one on which lives can depend. A concrete, local, apolitical environmental grievance sits in the narrow tolerated space. A fight that will inevitably be framed as political, anti-authority, or anti-war, or that cannot avoid contact with a banned "undesirable" organisation, carries severe personal danger. Judge this honestly and soberly before you act, and let it shape everything that follows.

Reading the Answers

Work the five questions together and a picture forms. **A concrete, imported harm rejected by a large local public, with a federal-versus-regional angle**, points toward disciplined local mobilisation plus procedural pressure — the shape of Russia's real victories. **A procedural violation** points toward the expertise process, the prosecutor, and the courts, pursued technically and apolitically. **A threat to a protected-eligible site** points toward the protected-areas route. **A strategic, remote, state-backed project** points toward the realistic and safer goals of documentation, forced honest assessment, mitigation, and compensation — pursued with extreme care and no illusions.

Naming Your Realistic Goal

Before you go further, write down, with a small trusted group, what winning would actually mean — concretely, honestly, and safely. Depending on your situation, a realistic goal might be: stopping or relocating the project; forcing a genuine assessment and real public consultation; securing or invoking protected status for the site; triggering enforcement of the state's own standards; winning delay, mitigation, or fair compensation; or building the documented record that constrains the project later. A narrow goal that fits your situation keeps your community focused and safe, and prevents the demoralisation of measuring a real, partial, protective win against an all-or-nothing standard. In Russia, a well-chosen narrow goal, pursued with discipline and care, is not a retreat — it is the only path that both protects the place and protects your people.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Documentation is the foundation of everything that follows, and in Russia it carries a special weight and a special caution. Because open confrontation is dangerous and courts will not act on politics, the only argument that has a chance is "this project violated a specific rule, and here is the proof." A community that can show — in dated, sourced, organised form — exactly what the project is, what the law required, and where the process or the pollution breached it, holds something that can, on occasion, move an inspectorate, a prosecutor, the expertise process, or the authorities' own preference to defuse a grievance. A community that has only anger has something that, in Russia, is more likely to bring danger than results.

The Mindset: Build a Record for the State's Own Procedures — Carefully

Approach documentation as if you are assembling a file that a Rosprirodnadzor inspector, a prosecutor, or an expertise reviewer will read — people who can act only on concrete, provable violations of specific rules, framed in strictly technical, apolitical terms. Everything must be dated, attributed to a source, and stored so it cannot be lost or seized. And it must be gathered safely: in Russia, the act of documenting can itself draw suspicion, so weigh how and where you record, keep sensitive material secure, and never let the file stray into political territory that could expose you under the wartime information laws.

What to Document

The project itself. Its exact location and boundaries; its type, scale, and outputs; the developer and its backers; the stage it has reached; and every official document you can obtain — the plan, the OVOS materials and impact statement, the public-hearing records, the State Environmental Expertise conclusion, the permits, and the land, forest, water, or subsoil allocations. The official paper trail is the spine of your case.

The procedure — and its violations. This is the heart of a Russian challenge. Was an OVOS carried out for a project that required one? Was the public hearing genuinely announced, accessible, and conducted, or was it hidden, stage-managed, or skipped? Were the materials made truly available and objections recorded and answered? Was the State Environmental Expertise obtained, and did it rest on genuine consultation? Each gap between what the law required and what happened is a documented violation — and the absence of required public consultation is, in principle, a ground on which a decision can be challenged and works halted.

The protected-area and resource status. Establish whether the site holds, or could qualify for, specially protected natural status, and document the specific land, forest, water, or subsoil designations at stake. A project encroaching on a protected area, or resting on an unlawful resource allocation, is exposed on concrete, documentable grounds.

The physical and health baseline. Photograph and date the forest, river, air, and homes as they are now, with locations recorded. Note water sources, protected species and habitats, and the proximity of homes, schools, and drinking water to the site. This baseline shows what is at risk and lets you later prove what changed. Where possible, obtain independent expert assessment — though be aware that a person labelled a "foreign agent" is barred from providing environmental expertise, so choose experts and framing with care.

The community and the impact. Who lives here, how many families the project touches, and what it would take from them. In Russia, a concentrated, concrete, local harm — kept strictly non-political — is both your most persuasive evidence and your safest.

Every interaction with authorities and the developer. Keep a dated log of every notice, hearing, request, and response — who said what, when, and with what document to prove it. When you file a request or complaint, keep it and the reply or the silence. This log is both your timeline and, when officials stonewall, evidence in itself.

How to Document Safely and Credibly

Safety governs documentation in Russia more than anywhere in this guide. Keep multiple copies in more than one place, including secure backups, and assume that devices, accounts, and communications may not be private. Record dates and sources for everything; prefer official documents and clear breaches of specific standards over rumour. Be accurate and restrained — a file that overstates can be dismissed and can expose you — and keep the framing rigorously technical and local: a matter of environmental law and a specific place, never of politics, authority, or the war. That framing is what lets the state's own procedures act on the file, and what keeps the people who gathered it as safe as circumstances allow.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This section turns documentation into a concrete list of sources. In Russia, more official material is nominally public than one might expect, and formal requests invoke real, if weakly enforced, rights — but every step must be taken with care for safety and framing. Work through these methodically.

Official Sources and Registers

OVOS and public-hearing materials. For listed projects, the environmental impact assessment materials and the notice, schedule, and records of the public hearing must be made available by the developer and the organising authority. Obtain them: they reveal the project's claimed impacts, the assessment's contents, and — checked against reality — whether the public participation genuinely happened. The hearing announcement and its timing and location are themselves evidence of whether the process was fair.

The State Environmental Expertise. The fact and conclusion of the expertise, and the materials submitted to it, establish whether the legally required review occurred and on what basis. A project proceeding without a required positive conclusion is exposed.

Rosprirodnadzor and the environmental authorities. The environmental inspectorate and the Ministry of Natural Resources publish standards, permits, inspection results, and enforcement actions. Use these to identify the standards your project must meet and to see the authorities' own record.

Land, cadastre, and resource records. The state real-estate register (Rosreestr) records parcels, boundaries, and rights, and land, forest, water, and subsoil allocations are documented by the relevant authorities. Use these to map the footprint and to test whether the resource rights were lawfully granted — and to establish any protected-area boundaries the project encroaches on.

Territorial and planning documents. Territorial plans and land-use documents, and the records of their public hearings, are official and obtainable. Secure the plan your project rests on and how it was adopted.

Documents You Request

Information requests to public bodies. Russian law provides for requests for information to state bodies, and for environmental information in particular. Request the OVOS materials, the expertise conclusion, permits, monitoring data, and the plan and its hearing records. A refusal or silence is itself significant and can be raised with the prosecutor. Keep every request and response — but frame each request narrowly and technically.

Complaints as records. A complaint to Rosprirodnadzor or the prosecutor not only reports a problem but generates an official record of what you raised and when — useful evidence, provided it is kept strictly to a technical environmental violation.

Independent Evidence

Scientific and technical expertise, and the Public Ecological Expertise. Russia has capable environmental scientists and specialists, and independent assessment can give your observations authority. The **Public Ecological Expertise** mechanism allows a qualifying public organisation to carry out its own environmental review of a project, whose registered and approved conclusion carries legal weight — one of the most substantial formal tools available to an organised community. Choose experts and organisations with care for their legal exposure, and remember that a "foreign agent" is barred from providing such expertise.

Surviving local and specialist networks. Although the large federal and international organisations have been shut down or banned, local environmental groups, specialists, and defenders' support networks survive in places and carry

hard-won experience. Connect carefully and securely; they can help you read an assessment, identify a violation, and navigate the procedures and the dangers. Never involve, cite, or cooperate with an organisation designated "undesirable" — doing so is itself a crime.

Media archives and prior cases. The record of past Russian environmental fights — which landfill was stopped, which hill was protected, which whale population saved, and how — is a guide to what works and what is dangerous. Independent and exile outlets and surviving local reporting document many of these; study the cases that resemble yours, with attention to how the successful ones stayed local and apolitical.

The Federal-Versus-Local and Protected-Area Angles

Because your narrow levers are the federal centre's occasional preference to defuse a local grievance, and the protection of special natural areas, gather with special care: evidence that the project imposes one region's or city's burden on your community, and evidence that the site holds or merits specially protected status. These are the facts most likely to open the two doors that have, in practice, let Russian communities through.

Turning Sources into a Case

As you gather, sort everything against the chain of decisions from Section 2, so each document attaches to the stage and the rule it concerns. By the end you should be able to point to a specific decision or discharge, name the rule or standard that governed it, and show — with a dated, sourced document — where it failed. That is the raw material of every complaint, every request, every use of the expertise process, and every careful approach to the channels that the rest of this guide describes.

Researchers for Hire, and Everyday Research Tools

If digging through corporate filings, agency files and environmental records is beyond a few volunteers, you can hire it out — and this lifts a real weight off novice activists. The field is **opposition research** (or, on the labour side, **corporate-campaign research** — the same methods unions use to expose an employer's finances and record, turned on a developer). For your side, seek **opposition-research firms**, **licensed private investigators** with paid records access, **investigative journalists and freelancers** (often the cheapest, and they publish what they find), **environmental-compliance auditors** to dissect a developer's regulatory record, and **public-records / freedom-of-information specialists** to pry files loose. The investigative tools they use — and that a determined activist can use directly — include **OpenCorporates** and **OCCRP Aleph** (company ownership and cross-border links, worldwide) and **DocumentCloud** (search and OCR large document dumps), with **SEC EDGAR**, **LittleSis** and **MuckRock** as United States examples; most countries have their own equivalents.

For everyday, subject-agnostic research, a small kit goes far: **AI assistants** — Claude.ai, ChatGPT, Google Gemini, and Perplexity for sourced answers — are excellent for explaining a law, summarising a document, or drafting, so long as you **always verify** what they tell you, because they can invent citations; **Google Scholar** and Google's advanced search operators for studies and buried files; and the **Wayback Machine** for pages a developer or agency has quietly deleted.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documentation gives you a case; careful organisation gives it weight. But in Russia, organisation carries danger it does not carry elsewhere, and how you build opposition can determine both whether you succeed and whether your people stay free. This section is about building opposition that is effective, disciplined, and — above all — strictly local, apolitical, and as safe as the circumstances allow.

The Overriding Rule: Strictly Local, Strictly Apolitical

Russia's successful community campaigns share one feature above all: they were rigorously local and non-political — ordinary residents defending a specific place from a specific harm, never a movement, never a challenge to the authorities, never connected to opposition or anti-war politics. This is not only the safest posture; it is the only one with a chance, because it lets the authorities treat the grievance as a concrete local matter to be managed and, sometimes, resolved — rather than as a threat to be crushed. The moment a fight is framed as political, or is linked to a banned "undesirable" organisation, or touches the war, its risk becomes extreme and its chance of success collapses. Keep it about the landfill, the river, the forest, the hill — and nothing else.

Start With a Small, Trusted Core

Begin with a small, committed, trusted group, and be conscious from the first day that communications may be monitored and that infiltration is a real risk. Agree on your narrow goal, divide the work discreetly, and agree how you will make decisions and communicate securely. Keep sensitive planning within a trusted circle. A clear, careful core prevents the disorganisation and the exposure that can wreck a campaign and endanger its people.

Widen Carefully

The concentrated affected community first. Map who is threatened — by the imported harm, the pollution, the loss of a valued place — and reach them directly and personally. In Russia's real victories, a large, concentrated, local public with a shared concrete stake was the essential and decisive foundation. And local expertise has mattered enormously: in the Far East, a Sakhalin community-and-specialist campaign helped protect a rare grey whale population from offshore development — a reminder that a credible, technical, local effort can achieve what confrontation cannot.

Neighbours and local specialists. Others facing the same facility, and residents with professional, scientific, or legal knowledge, keep the campaign credible, technical, and grounded. Local expertise is especially valuable given how dangerous outside connections have become.

Surviving local networks and defenders' support — with extreme care. Where safe local groups, specialists, or defenders' support networks exist, they add experience and capacity. Approach only with great caution and secure communication, verify who you are dealing with, and never involve a banned organisation.

Tactics That Fit Russia's Reality

Be clear-eyed and sober about the boundaries. Freedom of assembly in Russia is, in practice, severely constrained: gatherings require permits that are routinely denied, restrictive rules govern even single-person pickets, and since 2022 wartime laws have been used to prosecute activists, with well over a thousand arrests at rallies in a single recent year. Open, sustained, or political protest can bring heavy reprisals, and the organisers bear the greatest risk. And yet Russia's own history shows that large, disciplined, strictly-local, apolitical expressions of environmental concern have, in specific cases, caused authorities to resolve a grievance rather than face continued anger. The line between what is tolerated and what is punished is real, shifting, locally specific, and — since 2022 — far more dangerous than before, and no guide can tell you where it lies for you.

For that reason, this guide steers you first toward the channels that carry weight for the least risk: rigorous documentation; information requests; the formal OVOS and public-hearing participation; the Public Ecological Expertise; and complaints to Rosprirodnadzor and the prosecutor. Where a community nonetheless considers any public expression, it should do so only with clear-eyed knowledge of the grave risk, careful attention to keeping every action peaceful, strictly local, and apolitical, no single person over-exposed, legal support arranged in advance, and no illusion that this guide can make such action safe.

Whatever the mix, keep it disciplined, keep it framed as a lawful, local, environmental concern, protect the people who step forward above all, and guard against both burnout and despair by sharing the load and marking small gains. In Russia, the campaigns that endure and occasionally succeed are the ones that stay careful, local, and unbreakably non-political.

Hiring Help to Run the Campaign

You need not carry the whole campaign yourselves. A whole industry runs opposition campaigns for hire — the visible turnout at hearings, the public comment, the messaging and the media — known as **grassroots-for-hire** or **public-affairs / grassroots-advocacy** consulting. It usually serves whoever pays, most often the deep-pocketed side, but you can hire the same muscle for yours: **public-interest communications and PR firms, campaign and field-organising firms** that run turnout and canvassing, and, if the fight becomes a local vote, **ballot-measure consultants**. People outside that niche can carry a piece too — a **PR or crisis-communications firm, a campaign consultant, a digital-advocacy shop**, or a seasoned **community organiser** — taking weight off exhausted volunteers who feel they are carrying the opposition alone. Two rules hold. Hire them **transparently**, and never let anyone fake a grassroots front: that is *astroturfing* — dishonest, and ruinous if exposed; the aim is to amplify a real community, not fabricate one. And mind your **setting** — where public campaigning is repressed or dangerous this market may be absent and a visible "show" perilous, so favour trusted journalists and international allies over hired campaigners, and never let paid help expose your people.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES

Legal and quasi-legal action in Russia is narrow, and it will not defeat a strategically-backed project on its own — but it is real, and it is generally safer than open confrontation because it works through the state's own channels and stays technical. It creates records, forces process, and occasionally produces a result. This section explains the openings. It is not a substitute for a lawyer, and finding one experienced in environmental matters — and safe to work with — is an early task.

The Channels That Function, Within Limits

The OVOS and public-consultation challenge. The strongest procedural hook is the requirement of genuine public participation. Russian law provides that where a project's environmental decision was reached without the legally required public consultation, that decision can be challenged and, in principle, its validity terminated — and construction stopped by court order. A rigorously documented failure of the public hearing is therefore your highest-value procedural ground.

The Public Ecological Expertise. A qualifying public organisation may conduct its own environmental review of a project. Once registered and approved, its conclusion carries legal weight and can directly contest the basis of a project's approval. This is one of the few substantial formal tools an organised community holds — though it requires capacity, and those labelled "foreign agents" are excluded from providing it.

Administrative challenges to specific decisions. A person or organisation directly affected can challenge the legality of a specific administrative act — a permit, a land or resource allocation, an approval — in the administrative courts. These are constrained and will not overturn a strategic project on political grounds, but they can contest a concrete, documented illegality and create delay.

The protected-areas route. Where a site holds or can be given specially protected natural status, invoking or securing that status can lawfully place it beyond development. This route has, in practice, saved threatened places, and it is a distinctively powerful Russian lever where the site qualifies. The protection of Kushtau after the 2020 protests is the clearest illustration: what mass local pressure won, protected-area status then locked in, placing the hill beyond the reach of the mining that had threatened it. Where your site has documented natural, ecological, or heritage value, building the case for that status early gives a campaign a concrete, lawful objective that can outlast the immediate fight.

The Non-Court Channels That Often Matter More

In Russia, some of your most effective "legal" levers are not courts:

- **The prosecutor's office (prokuratura).** Its broad supervision of legality means a documented, apolitical environmental-law violation placed before it can, on occasion, prompt it to act against the project or the responsible officials — sometimes more effectively than a court.
- **Rosprirodnadzor enforcement.** A clear, documented breach of environmental standards reported to the inspectorate can trigger an inspection, a fine, or an order, and creates an official record.
- **Information-request and complaint procedures.** Forcing the release of withheld materials, and lodging technical complaints, both arm every other channel and put the authorities on notice.

Deadlines, Standing, and Safety

Three warnings. First, **deadlines are short.** The window to participate in a public hearing, and the periods to challenge a decision, are limited; diarise every one the moment you learn of it. Second, **standing is specific.** Public participation is open, but administrative challenges generally require that you be directly affected, and the Public Ecological Expertise requires a qualifying organisation; settle early who acts in what capacity. Third — and paramount in Russia — **weigh the safety of every legal step.** Using formal channels is far safer than open protest, but choosing counsel and partners carefully, keeping every filing strictly technical and apolitical, avoiding any contact with banned organisations, and never letting a matter be characterised as political or anti-war all bear directly on the security of the people involved.

What Legal Action Realistically Achieves

Be clear-eyed. In Russia, the procedural and quasi-legal channels can, at their best, force a defective process to be redone, contest a specific illegality, invoke protected status to save a site, and — through the prosecutor or the inspectorate — bring an apolitical violation to official attention. They will not, on their own, defeat a project the state prioritises, and courts will not rule against such a project on political grounds. But even then, these channels force honest process, impose delay, create the documented record, and — combined with a large, disciplined, strictly-local public grievance — occasionally

contribute to the outcome that has, in rare cases, been achieved here. Treat them as the lower-risk, disciplined engine of a careful campaign, worked in combination and never in isolation.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file full of documents. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a prosecutor, an inspector, an expertise reviewer, and a cautious official in different ways. In Russia, learning to translate your evidence for each audience, while keeping every version strictly technical, local, and apolitical, is what lets the file work — and what keeps it from becoming a danger.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that the public hearing on the project's environmental impact assessment was announced only obscurely and held where affected residents could not attend, and that objections went unrecorded. That one fact becomes:

- **A procedural-challenge argument:** the environmental decision was reached without the legally required public consultation, and is therefore open to challenge and, in principle, to termination — with construction halted.
- **A prosecutorial argument:** an official process was conducted in breach of the environmental-participation requirements, a legality question the prosecutor's office supervises.
- **An expertise argument:** the State Environmental Expertise rested on a defective, unlawful consultation and is open to contest, including through a Public Ecological Expertise.
- **A local-grievance argument (kept strictly apolitical):** "They decided about our forest and our water without letting us be heard" — a concrete, local, non-political statement of a specific wrong.

Same fact, four arguments, four audiences. Go through your strongest documented facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and every entry in it must stay technical and local.

Match the Argument to the Audience

Prosecutors and inspectors want a concrete, provable violation of a specific rule or standard, presented technically and without political content. Keep it precise, sourced, and unemotional; show the breach and the legality question it raises.

The expertise process and the courts want the elements of a procedural or substantive defect: which requirement, which failure, which proof, which remedy. Give them the organised file.

Local officials want to avoid a growing, visible local grievance — especially one that could draw unwelcome attention from above. Show them, carefully and without threat, that the project as it stands carries the risk of a documented illegality and of sustained local anger, and that following the rules avoids both.

The local public (kept strictly apolitical) wants the concrete stakes made plain: the water, the forest, the air, the imported burden, the specific place at risk. Lead with the place and the harm; supply the fact that proves it; and never let it drift toward politics, authority, or the war.

The Master Frame: "A Local, Lawful, Environmental Concern"

Across every audience, the strongest and safest frame in Russia is the same, and it is unusually strict: you are not opposing the authorities, you are not political, and you have nothing to do with the war or with any banned organisation — you are law-abiding local residents asking that the state's own environmental rules be followed and a specific place protected. This frame is accurate; it is essential for safety, because it keeps you within the narrow tolerated space; and it is the only frame that gives the state's own procedures — and its occasional preference to defuse a local grievance — a reason to work in your favour. In a system that criminalises political dissent but sometimes resolves a concrete local environmental complaint, keeping your fight rigorously within that boundary is both your best lever and your protection.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and public attention can raise the cost of a harmful project — but in Russia this is the most dangerous tool in the kit, and it must be used with extreme care. Attention that stays strictly local, factual, and apolitical can, on occasion, draw the notice of authorities who would rather resolve a grievance than let it grow; attention that turns political, national, or anti-

war, or that involves a banned outlet or organisation, can bring prosecution under the wartime information laws. Use it deliberately and narrowly, in service of a local goal, and never as a substitute for the documentation and procedural work beneath it.

What Coverage Can and Cannot Do

Careful, local attention can pressure officials who dislike the appearance of a mishandled local problem, reach neighbours and specialists who can help, and, in the right circumstances, signal to higher authorities that a purely local environmental grievance is generating anger they may prefer to defuse. It cannot, in Russia, safely be used to build political opposition or a national movement, and coverage that crosses into political or anti-war territory is far more likely to endanger participants than to help. Russia's community victories drew attention while staying rigorously within the local, apolitical frame.

Build the Story Around the Place, Proof, and Restraint

The safest and most effective Russian environmental story combines a concrete local stake with a documented fact, kept strictly to the environment and the specific place — the forest, the river, the imported waste, the threatened hill — and never to politics. Avoid political framing entirely; avoid any suggestion of a movement or of opposition; keep the message narrow, factual, and repeatable: what the project is, what specific harm it poses, what rule was broken, and what lawful protection you are asking for.

Reach the Layers That Matter — Carefully

Official and semi-official channels — the complaint and request procedures, formal letters — are both "media" and evidence in Russia, putting your concern on the record with the bodies that can act. **Surviving local and regional reporting**, where a narrow local environmental story can sometimes still find space, can reach the affected public and attentive officials. **Independent and exile outlets** may cover a significant fight, but engaging them carries real risk under the wartime and "undesirable" and "foreign agent" laws, and must be weighed with great care; never share links to or cooperate with a designated "undesirable" outlet, as that is itself criminalised. **Online and social channels**, kept strictly local and apolitical, can inform and coordinate — but carry serious risk of both surveillance and, if read as political or anti-war, of prosecution; use them cautiously and never as the campaign's centre.

Discipline and Safety Above All

Be accurate always; a single exaggeration can discredit the campaign and expose you. Stay narrow, local, and apolitical without exception. Anticipate that any attention may be characterised as political troublemaking, and pre-empt it by grounding everything in environmental law and the specific place. Protect the people involved above all: share any public-facing role, brief everyone soberly on the grave risks, arrange legal support in advance, and never let attention pull participants into an action whose danger they did not fully understand and choose. In Russia more than anywhere, the media strategy that works is the quiet, careful, strictly-local, apolitical one that amplifies a documented case to the officials and authorities who might act — not the loud one, which here can lead to prison.

Amplifying at Scale — Media Help for Hire

Beyond pitching reporters yourselves, you can pay to spread the story at scale — different from a single advert or one call to a local outlet, and available at any reach from local to global. **Public-relations and communications firms** run earned-media campaigns — placing op-eds, orchestrating coverage, staging the media push; for the cause side, public-interest firms such as Fenton, BerlinRosen and M+R work for advocacy groups and unions, not only corporations. **Press-release / newswire distribution services** send a release across a wide network of journalists and outlets — PR Newswire, Business Wire and GlobeNewswire at the global, higher-budget end; EIN Presswire, PRWeb and eReleases far cheaper and nonprofit-friendly, some with cause-specific wires. And **digital and social amplification** shops run targeted paid campaigns and creator partnerships. Two rules: amplify a *true* story from a *real* community — never manufacture fake outrage; and where public visibility is dangerous, favour trusted journalists and international allies over paid amplification.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you create records, invoke your rights, and put the authorities on notice — and in Russia, a written, filed, strictly-technical submission is far safer and often more effective than any public action. Every letter does

double duty: it asks for something, and it documents that you asked, so that a response or silence becomes evidence. Keep copies of everything. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, narrow, technical, and framed around environmental law and a specific place — never political, never touching authority or the war.

8A. Request for Environmental Information

To: the competent environmental authority / the project developer **Subject:** Request for environmental information — [project / location]

I am a resident of [area] affected by [project]. Under the environmental-information provisions of the Federal Law "On Environmental Protection," I request: the environmental impact assessment (OVOS) materials and impact statement; the notice and records of the public hearing; the State Environmental Expertise conclusion; the project's permits and their conditions; and environmental monitoring data. Please provide these within the period established by law. If any item is withheld, please state the specific legal basis.

8B. Objection at the OVOS Public Hearing

To: the authority and developer conducting the public participation **Subject:** Comments on the environmental impact assessment — [project / location]

Within the public participation period announced on [date], I submit the following comments as an affected resident. **First**, the assessment does not adequately evaluate [water / forest / air / protected-area / proximity] impacts, in that [specific deficiency]. **Second**, [further substantive deficiency]. **Third**, the public participation itself was deficient, in that [e.g., the notice, location, timing, or accessibility did not meet the requirements of the OVOS Regulations and the Federal Law "On Ecological Expertise"]. I request that these be addressed before any State Environmental Expertise, and that I be notified in writing of the outcome. I ask that these comments be entered in the record.

8C. Complaint to the Environmental Inspectorate (Rosprirodnadzor)

To: the territorial office of Rosprirodnadzor **Subject:** Report of an environmental violation — [project / location]

I report the following apparent violation at [location]: [describe — e.g., works without a required State Environmental Expertise; construction or discharge breaching standard X; encroachment on a protected natural area], evidenced by [dated documents / photographs attached]. I request an inspection and, where a violation is confirmed, appropriate enforcement measures, and written notification of the action taken.

8D. Application to the Prosecutor's Office

To: the [district / regional] prosecutor's office **Subject:** Request to check the legality of [project / decision]

I ask the prosecutor's office, in exercise of its supervision of legality, to check whether [project / decision] at [location] complies with environmental legislation. Specifically, [set out the documented violation — e.g., approval without the required environmental expertise; a public hearing conducted in breach of the requirements; an unlawful resource allocation]. The supporting evidence is attached. I request that measures be taken to remedy any violation found, and that I be informed of the result.

8E. Administrative Challenge to a Specific Decision

To: the higher authority or the administrative court, as advised by counsel **Subject:** Challenge to decision [number / date] — [project]

As a resident directly affected by [the decision — e.g., the approval / permit / land allocation], I challenge it on the grounds that it was adopted in breach of [the specific requirement — e.g., the public-consultation requirement, absence of which permits the decision to be challenged and its validity terminated]. The specific defects are [list, each with the rule and the proof]. I request that the decision be invalidated and the matter conducted lawfully.

8F. Initiating a Public Ecological Expertise

To: [the qualifying public organisation / the registering authority] **Subject:** Public Ecological Expertise of [project]

[As / on behalf of] a public organisation whose activities include environmental protection, we notify our intention to

conduct a Public Ecological Expertise of [project], as provided by the Federal Law "On Ecological Expertise," and request registration of this expertise and access to the project materials necessary to conduct it. [Set out the organisation's standing and the scope proposed.]

8G. Petition for Protected-Area Status

To: the competent authority for specially protected natural areas **Subject:** Request to protect [site]

We request that [site] at [location] be granted specially protected natural status under the Federal Law "On Specially Protected Natural Areas," on the grounds that it possesses [the specific natural / ecological / heritage values documented]. The site is threatened by [project]. We attach supporting evidence and request consideration and a written response.

8H. Letter to Local Representatives and Authorities

To: [local / regional deputies / the administration] **Subject:** [Project] — request to protect residents and the environment lawfully

As residents of your area, we ask you to help ensure that [project] complies with environmental law and does not harm [the specific place / water / residents], given its [documented] risks and the [documented] deficiencies in its assessment and public consultation. We ask you to [specific request — seek the documents, ensure a lawful hearing, support protection of the site]. We seek only that the law be followed and our community's environment protected.

Using the Templates Well

File important submissions so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline. Keep them factual, specific, narrow, and calm; attach your evidence; ask for a written response by a date; and keep every version rigorously technical and local, never political. The reply — or the silence — becomes part of your record, and in Russia that record is both what can move the state's own procedures and part of what keeps the people who filed it safe.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes the public-hearing notice is already posted, the expertise is imminent, or the survey crews have arrived, and you cannot read this whole guide first. This is the compressed version. Do these things, in this order — and keep every step strictly local, apolitical, and as safe as possible.

1. Find out exactly where the project is in the approval chain, today. Is the OVOS or its public hearing under way, has the State Environmental Expertise been issued, or is land being taken and construction begun? This tells you which window is open and which deadline is nearest. In Russia these windows are short.

2. Submit your written comments or information request now, even if imperfect. If a public hearing period is open, submit written comments and ask that they be entered in the record before it closes. Simultaneously, request the OVOS materials, the expertise, and the permits under the environmental-information rules. This preserves your rights and starts your record — safely, through official channels.

3. Photograph and date the baseline, and identify the rule at stake. Capture the forest, water, homes, and any protected-area boundaries near the site, with dates. Identify the specific requirement the project appears to breach — a skipped consultation, a missing expertise, an encroachment on a protected area. The specific rule is your lever.

4. Gather a small, trusted core and name a narrow, realistic goal. A few trusted neighbours who meet this week beat many who are merely alarmed — and are far safer than a loose crowd. Decide together what winning means — stop or relocate it, force honest assessment, protect the site, win mitigation — and agree to keep the fight strictly local and apolitical.

5. Identify the weak link and the federal-versus-local angle. Pinpoint the challengeable defect, and whether the project imposes another region's or city's burden on your community — because that is the dynamic that has, in practice, drawn higher authorities to resolve a local grievance.

6. Use the formal channels — the hearing, the inspectorate, the prosecutor. Lodge your technical comments and complaints through the OVOS process, Rospirodnadzor, and the prosecutor's office. These are the levers the system is built to answer, and the safest to use.

7. Reach any safe local specialist or network — with care. Where a safe local group or specialist exists, they add capacity and experience, including on the Public Ecological Expertise. Approach only with secure communication and care, and never involve a banned "undesirable" organisation.

8. Keep any public expression strictly local, peaceful, and apolitical — and arrange legal support. If your community considers any public step, keep it rigorously to the environment and the place, peaceful, with no one over-exposed and no political or anti-war content, arrange legal help in advance, and understand soberly that even then, risk remains.

Do these eight things and you will have preserved your legal position, started your record, built a careful core, identified your lever, and engaged the official channels — all through the routes the system sometimes answers, and all while keeping your people as safe as circumstances allow. Then come back and read the rest, and read "When the System Is Tilted" with special care.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Russia's system is heavily tilted on projects the state wants, and since 2022 the ground has shifted further against any form of independent action. You must understand the tilt precisely — so you neither despair nor, far worse, act in ways that expose your people to prosecution.

Where the Tilt Shows

The executive and the security apparatus are powerful and, on a prioritised project, determined. Courts are not independent and will not rule against such a project on political grounds. Independent and federal environmental advocacy has been effectively dismantled: the largest organisations have been branded "undesirable" or "foreign agent" and forced to close or leave, cooperation with a banned organisation is a crime, and a person labelled a "foreign agent" is even barred from providing environmental expertise. Freedom of assembly is, in practice, near-extinct, with permits routinely denied and rallies met with mass arrests. And since the full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022, wartime laws against "discrediting the armed forces" and spreading "false information" have been turned against environmental activists, and some have been imprisoned, stripped of citizenship, or driven into exile. External leverage — international NGOs, foreign lenders, reputational pressure — which communities elsewhere rely on, has largely been severed by these bans and by sanctions. This is a decisive difference from most other places: a Russian community cannot count on a foreign parent company's investors, a development bank's safeguards, or an international campaign to carry its cause, because those channels have been cut off or criminalised. The leverage that remains is almost entirely domestic — the state's own procedures, the prosecutor, the inspectorate, protected-area status, and the weight of a disciplined local grievance — which is why this guide concentrates on them.

What Still Works — And Where

The crucial thing to hold onto is that even within this severe tilt, a narrow space remains, and it has produced real victories — but it works only by staying rigorously inside the system and outside politics.

The concrete local grievance is the tolerated space. Russia's real community wins — a northern region refusing a distant city's waste, a southern community saving a sacred hill — came from large, disciplined, strictly-local, apolitical mobilisation against a specific, tangible harm. The authorities, faced with sustained local anger that was plainly not political and not anti-state, chose in these cases to resolve the grievance rather than let it fester. This space is real, but it is narrow and conditional, and it has grown more dangerous since 2022.

The federal-versus-regional dynamic can open a door. When a project imposes one region's or city's burden on another's people, a purely local grievance can become one the federal centre itself prefers to defuse — sometimes intervening to stop a project to quiet regional anger. This dynamic has been decisive in more than one Russian victory.

Formal procedures and the protected-areas route still bite, narrowly. A project that skipped genuine public consultation is procedurally exposed, and a decision reached without it can in principle be challenged and halted; a Public Ecological Expertise can contest a project's basis; and securing protected status can lawfully save a site. These are limited and hard, but they are real and comparatively safer.

Delay and documentation compound. Even where nothing stops a project immediately, a rigorous, safely-held record of violations forces honest process, supports the prosecutor and the inspectorate, and constrains the project over time.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Russia is sober and it comes with a graver safety warning than any other in this guide. Outright, permanent victory against a determined, strategically-backed project is very unlikely, and pursuing it through open political confrontation is not only self-defeating but acutely dangerous — it can bring prison. But forcing honest assessment, contesting a procedural violation, securing protected status, triggering enforcement of the state's own standards, winning delay, mitigation, or compensation, and — through large, disciplined, strictly-local, apolitical grievance — occasionally moving even the authorities themselves are all things Russian communities have achieved. Diagnose the tilt accurately, keep everything rigorously technical, local, and non-political, use the state's own procedures, protect your people above all, and never let the fight be turned into the kind of confrontation the system now crushes without restraint. That is the only method that works here — and it is the method most likely to protect both the place and the people who defend it.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Sometimes what you face is not merely a system that favours development but genuine corruption — approvals bought, assessments falsified, resources allocated for the benefit of connected interests. Recognising this matters, because in Russia documented corruption is both a deeper obstacle and a distinct, and unusually delicate, line of attack.

Signs of Capture

Watch for the patterns that recur. An environmental expertise granted despite obvious defects, or a project proceeding without the required expertise at all. A public hearing that was faked, hidden, or stage-managed. Land, forest, water, or subsoil rights allocated on unusually favourable terms to a connected company. A regional or local administration unusually determined to protect a specific developer, expediting approvals and silencing objections. Enforcement that never comes, however clear the violation. Officials with undisclosed ties to the beneficiary. None of these alone proves corruption, but together they mark a decision captured by private and connected interests rather than made on the merits or in line with the law.

Why This Changes Your Strategy — and Where the Danger Lies

Genuine capture makes persuading the local authorities futile — the decision was never about the merits. And in Russia it also raises the stakes sharply, because those who benefit from a captured project may be powerful and protected, and exposing them can be dangerous. So this line of attack must be pursued with even greater care than the rest of this guide, and always in strictly legal, technical terms.

Where it can be pursued safely, documented corruption shifts the fight onto terrain where the state's own anti-illegality machinery may act:

- **The prosecutor's office and anti-corruption channels.** A documented, apolitical case that a project was approved unlawfully — without the required expertise, on a faked hearing, or through an unlawful resource allocation — is a legality question the prosecutor supervises, and one the state sometimes acts on, particularly where lower-level officials are implicated.
- **Transparency as attack, used carefully.** Forcing the underlying documents into the open through information requests can strip a captured decision of its cover and reveal the violation itself — while keeping you strictly within a lawful, technical frame.
- **Rosprirodnadzor enforcement.** A blatant, documented violation reported to the inspectorate can compel action the local administration avoided.

Document It Carefully and Safely

If you believe a decision is captured, document it with special care, restraint, and attention to your own safety, which in Russia is paramount. Distinguish always between what you can prove and what you suspect; allege only what your evidence supports; avoid naming powerful individuals speculatively; and preserve the concealment and the procedural violations themselves — the missing expertise, the faked hearing, the unlawful allocation — because these hard, specific, technical breaches are what the state's machinery can act on and are far safer to assert than unprovable claims about motives or powerful people. Build the file so that a prosecutor or an inspector could act on it, and frame it throughout as a matter of enforcing environmental and administrative law against a specific illegality — never as a political charge. In Russia, documented, technical illegality, pursued cautiously through the state's own legality channels, is one of the few ways a captured decision is ever undone — and reckless exposure of the powerful is one of the surest ways to bring harm

on yourself.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps in this guide are not a menu to pick from; they are strands to weave together over time, carefully and safely. This section shows how they combine into a single campaign, and roughly when each comes into play.

How the Strands Reinforce Each Other

The power of a Russian campaign comes from combining its channels while keeping every one of them narrow, technical, local, and non-political. **Documentation** feeds everything — the complaints, the requests, the procedural challenges, the expertise. **Formal participation and complaints** — the OVOS hearing, Rosprirodnadzor, the prosecutor — create records and can prompt action. **Legal and quasi-legal challenge** forces process and imposes delay. **The Public Ecological Expertise and the protected-areas route** offer substantive formal tools where a community has the capacity or the site qualifies. **Large, disciplined, strictly-local grievance** raises the political cost of an imported harm and, in the right circumstances, draws higher authorities to resolve it. Each strand strengthens the others: a documented violation becomes a complaint; the complaint becomes a prosecutorial check; the sustained local grievance makes the authorities prefer resolution. No single strand wins; woven together and kept safe, they have, in rare cases, prevailed.

A Rough Timeline

Early (first days and weeks). Diagnose the project and its stage; identify the weak link and the federal-versus-local angle; judge the risk soberly. Submit any hearing comments whose window is open and send your first information requests — deadlines are short. Photograph the baseline and pin down the rule at stake. Form a small, trusted, careful core and name a narrow, realistic goal. This early phase disproportionately shapes everything after, because missed windows and a lost baseline cannot be recovered.

Building (weeks to months). Deepen the documentation into a genuine file of specific violations. Lodge complaints with Rosprirodnadzor and the prosecutor; pursue information requests. Where capacity exists, prepare a Public Ecological Expertise or a protected-area petition; where a decision was reached without consultation, prepare a challenge. Keep any public or media dimension strictly local, factual, and apolitical, with legal support arranged. Pace yourself; this phase runs for months.

Sustained (months to years). Keep the documentation, the complaints, the procedural challenges, and any disciplined local grievance alive together, adapting as the project and the authorities respond. Maintain the core through setbacks, guarding against both burnout and despair by sharing the load and marking gains. Keep the framing rigorously technical, local, and non-political throughout — the discipline that keeps people safe is also the discipline that occasionally works.

Throughout. Reassess honestly and regularly. Is the situation responsive, mixed, or entrenched — and does your narrow goal still fit it, at an acceptable risk? If a lever works, press it; if the picture changes — a federal intervention, a policy shift, a hardening of repression — adapt, and if the danger to people rises beyond what any achievable outcome can justify, have the wisdom to protect your people, preserve your documentation for a safer time, and step back. Keep your documentation current and secure. And keep safety the first consideration at every step: in Russia there is no outcome worth a person's freedom or life, and the careful, lawful, local path is the only one that both protects the place and protects your people.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The Honest Bottom Line

Russia is one of the hardest and most dangerous places in the world in which to oppose a destructive project, and this guide has not pretended otherwise. Courts are not independent, independent advocacy has been dismantled, protest is near-criminalised, and since 2022 wartime laws have been turned against environmental activists. And yet Russia is also a place where communities have stopped and reshaped real projects — where a northern region refused to become a distant city's dumping ground and won, where a southern community saved a sacred hill and had it protected, where campaigners saved a rare whale population. Both halves of that picture are true, and holding both — without illusion and without despair — is the beginning of wisdom.

On a concrete, local, imported harm that a large community rejects, a disciplined, well-documented, rigorously apolitical

campaign has a narrow but real chance of forcing cancellation or protection, and a better chance of winning honest assessment, delay, and mitigation. On a threat to a site that can be given protected status, mobilisation has in rare cases saved the place. On a strategic, remote, state-backed project, outright stoppage is very unlikely and confrontation is dangerous — but forced honest assessment, contested violations, enforcement, delay, mitigation, and compensation remain achievable, and they protect real people. What is not achievable, and what is now acutely dangerous to attempt, is open political confrontation with the system; the method that works in Russia is the one that turns the state's own procedures and its occasional preference to defuse a local grievance to the protection of a specific place.

What Distinguishes the Campaigns That Win

The campaigns that achieve something in Russia share a pattern, and it is a strict one. They diagnose their situation and their risk honestly and set a narrow, fitting goal. They stay rigorously local and non-political, framing everything as lawful environmental concern about a specific place. They document specific violations with care, and they use the system's own channels — the hearing, the expertise, the inspectorate, the prosecutor, the protected-areas route. They build large, disciplined, careful local support and protect the people who step forward above all. And they endure, adapting as circumstances shift.

The campaigns that fail, or that bring harm to their people, do the opposite. They confront the authorities head-on; they let the fight be framed as political, national, or anti-war; they touch a banned organisation; they mobilise openly in ways that cross the ever-narrowing red line; or they measure a real, partial, protective win against an all-or-nothing standard the system is built to defeat.

A Closing Word

If you are reading this because a project threatens your forest, your water, your air, or your home, understand that even in Russia you are not entirely powerless — but understand equally, and above all, that how you act matters as much as whether you act, and that your safety and your neighbours' safety come first. The method is narrow and specific: diagnose your situation and your risk, document specific violations with care, keep everything strictly local, lawful, and apolitical, use the state's own procedures, build disciplined local support, protect your people, and endure. It does not guarantee victory, and it asks you to accept real limits and real danger. But used with discipline and care, it has delivered outcomes that protected real forests, real water, and real communities across Russia — and it can do so again, while keeping the people who fight as safe as circumstances allow. Judge your campaign by those outcomes, keep your people safe and free above all, and never trade their safety for a victory the system will not permit.